

The K. VijayRaghavan panel report has suggested sweeping changes in the set-up and functioning of the DRDO. These are the broad proposals, as compared to the current situation

Restructuring of 41 DRDO labs into 10 national labs; setting up of a defence technology roadmap, defence tech hubs in academic institutions

Strict performance accountability. Critical review of past 10 years' work, those not making cut may be marked for premature retirement

Project-based hiring for 3-5 years, after which 25 per cent would be absorbed. Stress on campus recruitment from colleges/varsities to attract talent

Private industry, start-ups, academia encouraged to make use of Rs 1 lakh crore corpus amount for interest-free financing to develop deep tech



"Panels formed to revamp DRDO were headed by outsiders with no idea of defence research and DRDO's functioning. It takes decades to build an organisation but no time to destroy it"

RAVI GUPTA, *Former DRDO scientist*

In the interim budget this year, Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman announced a scheme to set up a large fund to foster R&D in the private defence sector. The aim is to promote 'deep tech'—the integration of advanced technologies such as artificial intelligence, machine learning and robotics—in the sector, with a large corpus of Rs 1 lakh crore dedicated to long-term interest-free financing. The programme intends to encourage start-ups and private industry to utilise testing and validation facilities, receive guidance from the military and secure loans for the development of weapon systems.

Accustomed to cornering the entirety of defence research funds, it is easy to see why DRDO scientists are unhappy with this. "The committee has made a generic recommendation without actually delving into the nitty gritty of research and development. DRDO has invested years in developing a particular system and you cannot hand it over to a private player overnight," says a top DRDO scientist.

The other major change the panel suggests is in how DRDO recruits. Rather than hire directly, the panel wants DRDO to actively engage in campus recruitment from colleges and universities, thereby competing with the private sector to attract fresh and promising talent. The panel felt that people often chose DRDO as a last resort, after failing to find good private sector jobs.

A CASE FOR MORE ACCOUNTABILITY

The VijayRaghvan panel has stated that nearly 60 per cent of delays in DRDO projects are caused by internal issues, such as the absence of required technologies, while 17-18 per cent are due to armed forces' proclivity to constantly change goal posts and specifications. Bureaucratic red-tapism, too, chokes some projects. Now, a review of all ongoing projects is being done, with only the viable ones expected to survive. DRDO HQ has also asked its labs to quickly complete projects that are in the final stage of completion.

There is also the matter of managing and rationalising DRDO's manpower—7,500 scientists, around 10,000 defence research and technical staff and 12,500 administrative and other support staff. In addition, it has nearly 30,000 contractual staff working on specific projects. Much like the military's Agniveer scheme, the panel has proposed project-based hiring of individuals with PhDs and post-graduate qualifications for 3-5 years. After this period, around 25 per cent of them would be absorbed in the DRDO system. This, feels the panel, would retain high-quality manpower through a system of incentives and disincentives, with strict performance accountability. To weed out non-performers, the panel has suggested a critical review of the past 10 years of work and achievement. Those scientists not making the cut may be asked to take premature retirement. Employees in administration and allied services may also be shifted to other government ministries. The plans are ambitious, but will DRDO allow them? ■